

The Missing Mile

an essay by E. Kim · originally published in Apex Quarterly, Vol. 12

There is a stretch of coastline north of the city where the road bends inland and the sea is hidden for almost a mile. Walkers complain about this stretch. They say the path loses its purpose, that the sound of water keeps them company along the cliffs and then suddenly the wind turns dry and the gulls quiet down and the body, unprompted, starts to hurry. I used to walk it with my father. He said the missing mile was a kind of test, and that anyone who turned back when the sea disappeared had failed it without noticing.

The argument for keeping the road as it is rests on a small misunderstanding. When the council voted in 1981 to leave the bend untouched, they were not preserving a view. They were preserving an absence. The minutes from that meeting, which I read for the first time last winter, describe the decision as 'a refusal to make the journey legible.' The phrasing is clumsy but the intention is exact: a coastline that explains itself at every step does not give the walker anything to do.

I have come to think the missing mile is the most honest part of the walk. The cliffs perform. The water performs. The wildflowers, which appear in late April with a violence that surprises even the locals, perform. Only the inland bend is willing to be ordinary, and the people who turn back at that point have, I think, mistaken the absence of spectacle for the absence of meaning.